

The Standings Hold

Three weeks later, AI brand rankings barely moved - and the brands AI couldn't see stayed invisible. A 112-brand, two-wave stability study across six leading models.

June 2026 · Pablo Ulpiano González Castro

AIAS™ Measurement Program

If AI-generated brand recommendations reshuffled at random from week to week, no one would need to manage them. They don't. Third System™ re-measured five full category panels – 112 brands, six models, identical questions, twenty-one days apart at most – and the standings held. Which brands the models recall, and how consistently they recall them, is a stable property of the brand, not noise in the machine.

A brand's AI recall-consistency rank held $t_1 \rightarrow t_2$ in four of five categories. Recognition sat at ceiling almost everywhere – every established brand is “known”; the competition happens in recall. And invisibility proved the stickiest state of all: 56 of 57 brands below the recall floor at first measurement were still there three weeks later.

second.

The implication: a brand's AI standing is a managed asset with inertia – it neither decays in days nor improves by waiting. If your brand is absent from the AI conversation today, that is its standing until something changes it.

Three findings, one implication. First, stability: per-brand recall-consistency rankings correlated strongly across waves in skincare, cosmetics, automotive, and premium spirits (rank correlations 0.76-0.96); only audiophile headphones – the smallest panel – failed the bar. Second, ceiling: AI recognition of established brands is saturated. In four of five categories, effectively every brand was recognized by every model, both waves. Recognition no longer discriminates; recall does. Third, persistence of absence: brands that failed to surface in AI recall at the first wave almost universally failed again at the

What we measured

Two identical measurement waves, fifteen to twenty-one days apart, across five locked category panels: audiophile headphones (16 brands), skincare, cosmetics, automotive, and premium spirits (24 each). Each wave asked six leading AI models - two each from Anthropic, OpenAI, and Google - the same recognition and recall questions, word for word, under the AIAS™ measurement protocol. Recognition asks whether a model knows the brand; recall asks whether the model

surfaces it unprompted when a buyer-style question is posed.

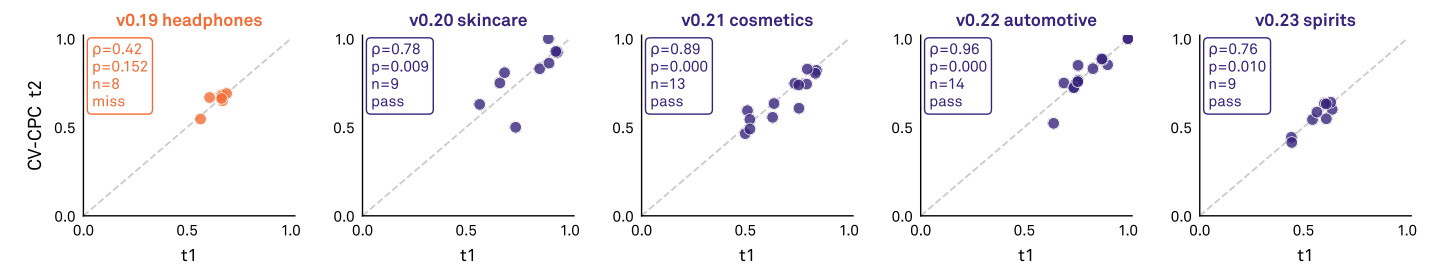
From per-model recall we compute a consistency score per brand; the study tests whether each brand's scores, ranks, and visibility status at wave one predict wave two. Probe wording, brand registries, and model identities were locked and externally registered before a single second-wave call was made.

FINDING 01

The standings held through the wait

CV-CPC rank order holds from t1 to t2 in four of five substrates

Per-brand CV-CPC at t1 vs t2; identity diagonal dashed. Defined both waves (mean recall >= 1.0).
Indigo = passes 0.70 criterion; warm = miss (v0.19, rho=0.42, n.s., n=8).



P1 SUPPORTED — recall-consistency standings held in four of five categories; the miss is the smallest, most fragmented panel.
Source: AIAS™ v0.34 (CPC Longitudinal t1->t2 Stability) | Protocol v0.34-prereg-r1 | Third System™

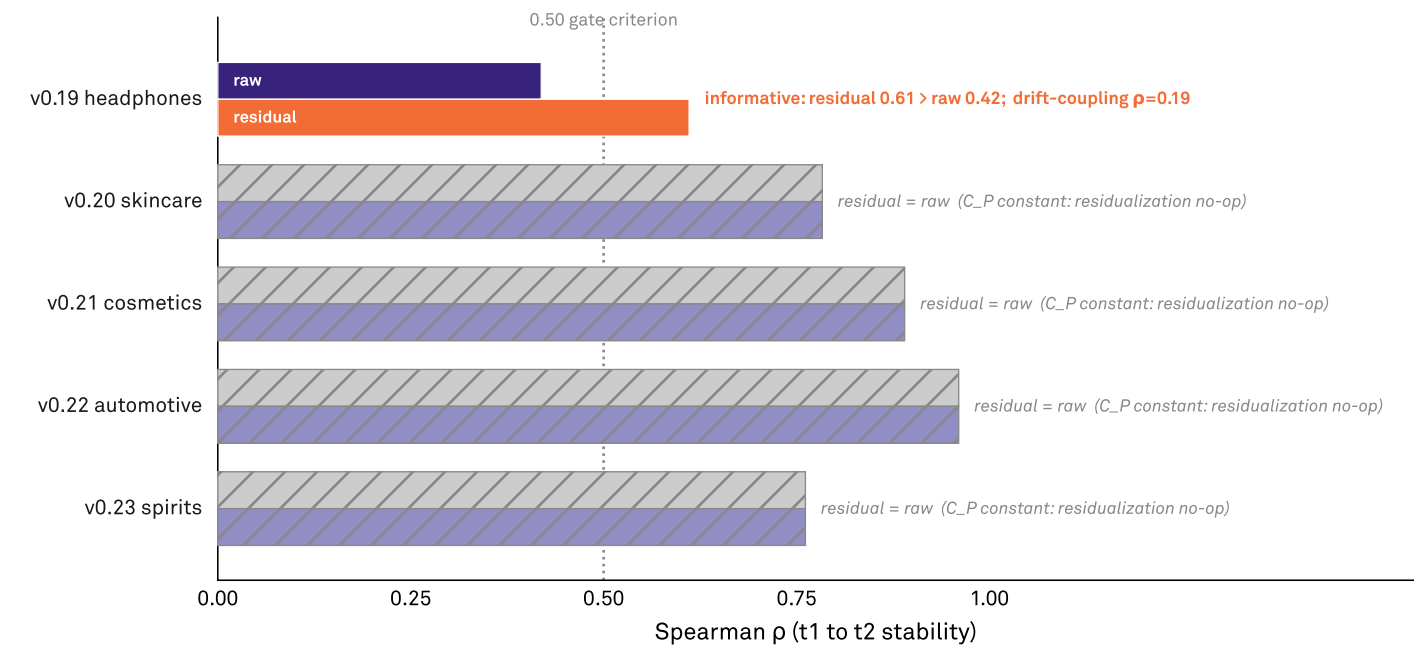
The standings held. Each brand's recall-consistency score at the first wave plotted against the second; points hug the diagonal in four of five categories. Audiophile headphones (warm) is the lone miss — the smallest, most fragmented panel. Rank correlations by category - headphones 0.42 (miss; smallest panel, n=8 comparable brands), skincare 0.78, cosmetics 0.89, automotive 0.96, spirits 0.76; the pre-registered bar was 0.70 in at least four of five.

FINDING 02

The question recognition wouldn't let us ask

The Beyond-Presence gate is informative in only one substrate

Raw vs Presence-residualized CV-CPC stability. $\rho(dCV-CPC, dC_P)$ is null wherever C_P is constant.
Hatched/muted = recognition-saturated (v0.20-v0.23): residual = raw. v0.19 is the lone informative substrate.



P2 NOT ESTABLISHED — the independence test could only run where recognition varies; four of five categories sat at the recognition ceiling.
Source: AIAS™ v0.34 (CPC Longitudinal t1->t2 Stability) | Protocol v0.34-prereg-r1 | Third System™

The question recognition wouldn't let us ask. Recall-consistency stability before and after accounting for recognition; the two are identical wherever recognition is saturated (four categories), so there is nothing to separate. Only headphones — where recognition still varies — is informative, and there consistency is steadier once recognition is removed.

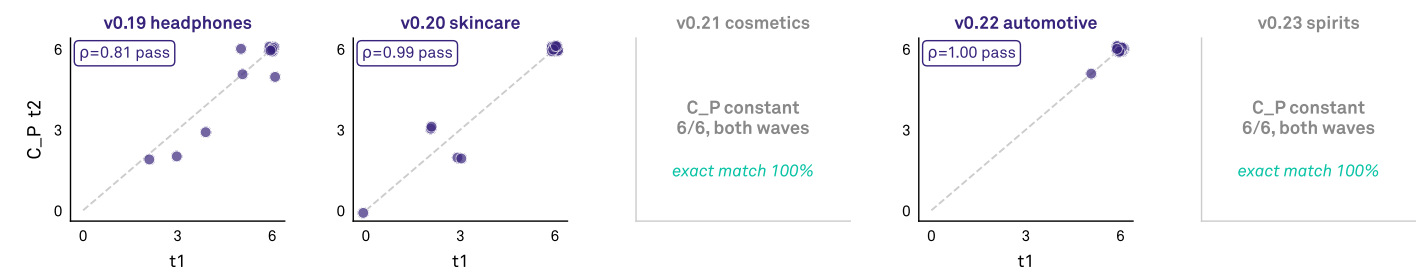
The test requires recognition to vary; in four categories every model recognized at least nine in ten established brands both waves, collapsing the test onto recall itself. In headphones - the only category with recognition variation - consistency was more stable after recognition was accounted for (0.61 vs 0.42), the study's one suggestive sign of an independent consistency signal.

FINDING 03

Recognition held where there was a ranking to hold

Presence is stable where measurable; saturated to a constant in two substrates

Per-brand C_P (0-6) at t1 vs t2; 0.80 criterion. Degenerate panels shown honestly (no fabricated rho).
v0.21 & v0.23: C_P at the 6/6 recognition ceiling both waves — rank-degenerate; exact-match supplement instead.



P3 SUPPORTED WHERE MEASURABLE — recognition standings held wherever there was a ranking to hold; two categories were a constant ceiling, both waves.
Source: AIAS™ v0.34 (CPC Longitudinal t1->t2 Stability) | Protocol v0.34-prereg-r1 | Third System™

Recognition held where there was a ranking to hold. Recognition scores wave-over-wave; strong wherever brands still differ, but two categories sit at a perfect ceiling both waves, leaving nothing to rank.

Recognition rank correlations 0.81 / 0.99 / 1.00 where perfect six of six models, both waves - 100% exact match, but measurable; in cosmetics and spirits every brand scored a no ranking to test.

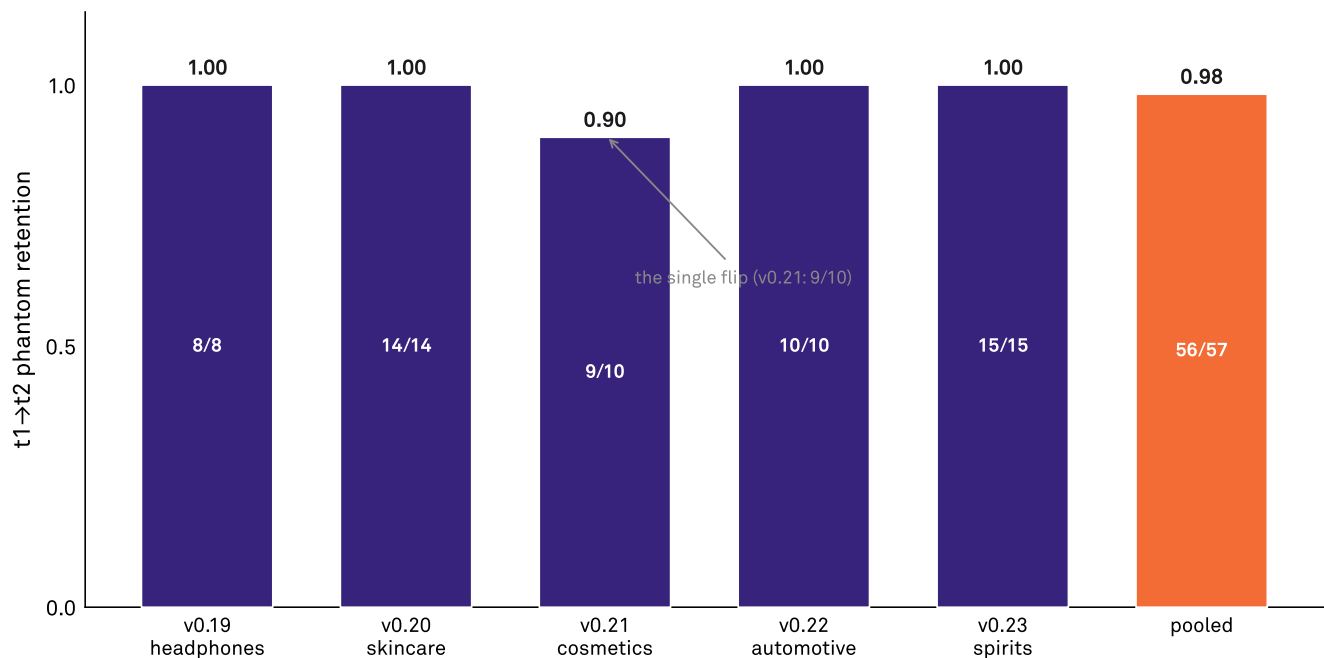
FINDING 04

Invisibility is the stickiest state

Phantom status is near-perfectly persistent across the interval

Share of t1 below-recall-floor (phantom) brands retaining phantom status at t2.

Descriptive (tertiary); no confirmation threshold. Pooled 56/57.



P4 OBSERVED — brands below the recall floor stayed there, 56 of 57; AI invisibility is a standing condition, not a bad week.

Source: AIAS™ v0.34 (CPC Longitudinal t1 to t2 Stability) | Protocol v0.34-prereg-r1 | Third System™

Invisibility is the stickiest state. The share of brands below the recall floor at the first wave that stayed below it at the second — 56 of 57 across all five categories, a single mover in cosmetics.

Retention of below-floor status - 8/8, 14/14, 9/10, 10/10, 15/15; pooled 56/57 (98%). The single mover was one cosmetics brand.

In summary

The stability is not uniform - it is structured, and the structure is informative. The four categories that passed are mature consumer categories with deep editorial and review coverage; their AI standings look like settled consensus. The one miss, audiophile headphones, combines the smallest panel with the most enthusiast-driven, fragmented discourse - the conditions under which a ranking plausibly should wobble.

Meanwhile recognition's ceiling effect tells brand teams where the game is: the models know your brand exists; the question is whether they bring it up. And the near-perfect persistence of the invisible cohort - fourteen of fourteen unsurfaced skincare brands still unsurfaced, fifteen of fifteen spirits - is the strongest managerial signal in the study: AI invisibility is a standing condition, not a sampling accident.

Limitations

Honest boundaries. The consistency instrument remains entangled with recognition-and-recall presence (a known limitation, documented in the program's methodology track); this study measures the stability of the quantity, not its validity as an independent construct. The interval is three weeks - stability over quarters is a separate, unanswered question. Models were called by their public names, as a real

buyer's tool would; any silent provider-side version change inside the window is part of what "stability" means here, by design. Five categories and 16-24 brands per panel bound the precision of any single category's result. And because recognition sat at ceiling, the study could not cleanly test whether consistency moves independently of presence - one category suggests it does; four could not speak.

What's next

The program's next methodology phase replaces the presence-entangled consistency instrument with a mean-independent one - this study's ceiling effects are direct evidence for why. The second wave also captured each provider's dated model version per call, which the first wave

could not; that establishes the baseline for a future third wave able to separate "the model changed" from "the answers drifted." And the open managerial question is the actionable one: if invisibility is sticky, what interventions move a brand across the recall floor - and how long do they take to register?

The four propositions, scored

Each proposition is the managerial reading of a locked result, scored for brand teams rather than reviewers.

#	Proposition	Status
P1	AI recall-consistency standings hold over weeks.	SUPPORTED — 4 of 5 categories at or above the pre-registered bar
P2	Consistency moves independently of recognition.	<i>NOT ESTABLISHED — testable in only 1 of 5 categories - recognition saturated elsewhere; the one informative category is suggestive, not sufficient</i>
P3	Recognition standings hold over weeks.	<i>SUPPORTED WHERE MEASURABLE — strong in all 3 categories with rank variation; 2 categories at a constant ceiling both waves - nothing to rank</i>
P4	AI invisibility persists.	<i>OBSERVED — descriptive; 56 of 57 below-floor brands retained the status; no pass/fail threshold was set</i>

The first wave of this program established that AI systems hold measurable, structured brand standings. This study establishes that those standings persist - through three weeks, through whatever silent updates providers shipped, through 852 fresh probes. Stability is what makes a measurement worth managing: a number that holds still long enough to be moved deliberately. The brands with the most at stake are the ones the models never mention - because as of this measurement, nothing about waiting changes that.

About the Third System

The Third System describes a shift in how consumers make decisions: instead of browsing and comparing options directly, many now rely on AI systems to generate recommendations. In this environment, brands compete not only for human attention but for inclusion within AI-generated outputs. This creates a new competitive layer where visibility is determined by how AI systems interpret and surface brands.

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Methodology

This report presents findings from Third System's AI Availability research program. The AI Availability Score (AIAS) is an early-stage measurement framework introduced in Tri-System Brand Growth (Gonzalez Castro, 2026). Findings should be used directionally. Construct validity — the correlation between AI Availability and consumer behavior — has not yet been established and is the subject of Phase 3 of the research program. Methodology is published in full and versioned at thirdsystem.ai/methodology (current: v1.7). Registry construction is curated and reflects the framework's view of each category's competitive set; revisions are documented in the methodology log.

Citation

González Castro, P. U. (2026). *The Standings Hold: Longitudinal t1-t2 Stability of AI Brand Recall Consistency Across Five Categories (AIAS CPC, v0.34)*. Third System (SSRN pending). thirdsystem.ai/v34

Underlying datasets

Verdicts: osf.io/ec6wh/v34/v34_verdicts.json

Two-wave acquisition data: osf.io/ec6wh/v34/data/

Scoring code: osf.io/ec6wh/v34/scripts/score_v34.py

Pre-registration: osf.io/ec6wh/v34/prereg/ (tag v0.34-prereg-r1)

Methodology log: v0.34 (SSRN pending).

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